

An illustration of three children, two girls and one boy, standing on the wooden railing of the Ark. The girl on the left has long blonde hair with a pink bow and wears a pink dress. The girl in the middle has curly brown hair with a pink bow and wears a floral dress. The boy on the right has short brown hair and wears a white t-shirt. They are all smiling and looking towards a white dove flying in the sky, which is holding an olive branch. A vibrant rainbow arches across the sky behind the dove. In the background, a sailboat is visible on the water, and a small building sits on a hill. The scene is set during a bright, sunny day with soft clouds.

A PARASHA BOOK · PARASHAT NOACH

The Ark, the Dove and the Rainbow

starring Aviya, Tzofia & Lielle

נח

Meet the explorers



Aviya, Tzofia & Lielle are about to climb into Parashat Noach (Genesis 6:9–11:32). Everything they see on these pages comes straight from the pesukim — the plain meaning, the *peshat*. Each picture page is followed by the words of the Torah it comes from, in Hebrew and English, and a question to look for in the text.



1

A Man Who Walked with God

A Man Who Walked with God

This time, when Aviya opened the Chumash, a warm wind blew out of the pages — and the sisters were standing on a dusty hill. The land below was full of people, but it was full of chammas, too — people grabbing and hurting. "That's not how the world is supposed to be," said Tzofia. Aviya read: Noach was a righteous man, wholehearted in his generation. Noach walked with God. He had three sons: Shem, Cham and Yefet.

Look closely: What were the names of Noach's three sons?

Shem, Cham and Yefet (6:10).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 6:9-13

⁹ אֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת נֹחַ נֹחַ אִישׁ צַדִּיק תָּמִים הָיָה בְּדֹרֹתָיו אֶת־הָאֱלֹהִים הִתְהַלָּךְ־נֹחַ:

¹⁰ וַיּוֹלֶד נֹחַ שְׁלֹשָׁה בָנִים אֶת־שֵׁם אֶת־חָם וְאֶת־יֶפֶת:

¹¹ וַתִּשְׁחַת הָאָרֶץ לִפְנֵי הָאֱלֹהִים וַתִּמְלֵא הָאָרֶץ חָמָס:

¹² וַיִּרְא אֱלֹהִים אֶת־הָאָרֶץ וְהִנֵּה נִשְׁחָתָה כִּי־הִשְׁחִית כָּל־בָּשָׂר אֶת־דְּרָכָו עַל־הָאָרֶץ:

¹³ וַיֹּאמֶר אֱלֹהִים לְנֹחַ קֵץ כָּל־בָּשָׂר בָּא לִפְנֵי כִי־מְלֵאָה הָאָרֶץ חָמָס מִפְּנֵיהֶם וְהִנְנִי מַשְׁחִיתָם אֶת־הָאָרֶץ:

^{6:9} These are the generations of Noah: Noah was a just man and perfect in his generations, and Noah walked with God.

^{6:10} And Noah begot three sons, Shem, Ham, and Yefet.

^{6:11} The earth also was corrupt before God, and the earth was filled with violence.

^{6:12} And God looked upon the earth, and, behold, it was corrupt; for all flesh had corrupted its way upon the earth.

^{6:13} And God said to Noah, The end of all flesh is come before Me; for the earth is filled with violence through them; and, behold, I will destroy them with the earth.



2 Build an Ark!

Build an Ark!

God told Noah exactly how to build the ark: gopher wood, with rooms inside, covered with pitch inside and out. Three hundred cubits long, fifty wide, thirty high. A tzohar for light. A door in the side. And three decks: lower, second and third. Aviya showed Tzofia a cubit — from her elbow to her fingertips. "Three hundred of those?!" Tzofia gasped. Lielle banged two pieces of wood together to help.

Look closely: How many decks did the ark have?

Three — lower, second and third (6:16).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 6:14-16

¹⁴ עֲשֵׂה לְךָ תֵּבַת עֲצֵי-גֹפֶר קִנִּים תַּעֲשֶׂה אֶת-הַתֵּבָה וְכִפַּרְתָּ אֹתָהּ מִבִּיַּת וּמִחוּץ
בַּכָּפָר:

¹⁵ וְזֶה אֲשֶׁר תַּעֲשֶׂה אֹתָהּ שְׁלֹשׁ מֵאוֹת אַמָּה אָרְךְ הַתֵּבָה חֲמִשִּׁים אַמָּה רָחְבָּהּ
וּשְׁלֹשִׁים אַמָּה קוֹמָתָהּ:

¹⁶ צֹהַר תַּעֲשֶׂה לַתֵּבָה וְאַל-אַמָּה תִּכְלְנָהּ מִלְּמַעְלָה וּפֶתַח הַתֵּבָה בְּצִדָּהּ תַּשִּׂים
תְּחִתָּיִם שְׁנַיִם וּשְׁלֹשִׁים תַּעֲשֶׂה:

^{6:14} Make thee an ark of gofer wood; rooms shalt thou make in the ark, and shalt pitch it within and without with pitch.

^{6:15} And this is the fashion of which thou shalt make it: the length of the ark shall be three hundred cubits, the breadth of it fifty cubits, and the height of it thirty cubits.

^{6:16} A window shalt thou make to the ark, and to a cubit shalt thou finish it above; and the door of the ark shalt thou set in its side; with lower, second, and third stories shalt thou make it.



3 Two by Two

Two by Two

Noach went into the ark with his sons, his wife, and his sons' wives, because of the waters of the flood. And then the animals came — two by two, male and female, just as God had commanded. Two elephants. Two giraffes, ducking their heads. Two tiny ladybugs. Tzofia counted them all: "Two! Two! Two!" Lielle waved at a pair of monkeys, and the monkeys waved back.

Look closely: Who went into the ark with Noach?

His sons, his wife and his sons' wives (7:7).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 7:7-9

⁷ וַיָּבֹא נֹחַ וּבָנָיו וְאִשְׁתּוֹ וְנִשְׁי־בָנָיו אִתּוֹ אֶל־הַתֵּבָה מִפְּנֵי מִי הַמַּבּוּל:

⁸ מִן־הַבְּהֵמָה הַטְּהוֹרָה וּמִן־הַבְּהֵמָה אֲשֶׁר אֵינָנָה טְהוֹרָה וּמִן־הָעוֹף וְכָל־
אֲשֶׁר־רֶמֶשׂ עַל־הָאֲדָמָה:

⁹ שְׁנַיִם שְׁנַיִם בָּאוּ אֵלֶי־נֹחַ אֶל־הַתֵּבָה זָכָר וּנְקֵבָה כָּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה אֱלֹהִים אֶת־נֹחַ:

^{7:7} And Noah went in, and his sons, and his wife, and his sons' wives with him, into the ark, because of the waters of the flood.

^{7:8} Of clean beasts, and of beasts that are not clean, and of birds and of everything that creeps upon the earth,

^{7:9} there went in two and two to Noah into the ark, male and female, as God had commanded Noah.



4

The Door Closes

The Door Closes

In the six hundredth year of Noah's life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day, all the fountains of the great deep burst open and the windows of the sky opened up. Rain fell for forty days and forty nights. The sisters hurried up the ramp. Then Aviya read a line that made her stop: "And Hashem shut him in." The great door closed behind them — safe and dry.

Look closely: Who shut the door of the ark?

Hashem shut him in (7:16).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 7:11-16

¹¹ בַּשָּׁנָה שִׁש־מֵאוֹת שָׁנָה לְחַיֵּי נֹחַ בַּחֹדֶשׁ הַשֵּׁנִי בְּשִׁבְעָה־עָשָׂר יוֹם לַחֹדֶשׁ בַּיּוֹם הַזֶּה נִבְקְעוּ
כָּל־מַעְיֵנֹת תְּהוֹם רַבָּה וְאֲרָבַת הַשָּׁמַיִם נִפְתְּחוּ:

¹² וַיְהִי הַגֶּשֶׁם עַל־הָאָרֶץ אַרְבָּעִים יוֹם וְאַרְבָּעִים לַיְלָה:

¹³ בְּעֶצֶם הַיּוֹם הַזֶּה בָּא נֹחַ וְשֵׁם־וְחָם וְיֶפֶת בְּנֵי־נֹחַ וְאִשְׁתּוֹ וְשְׁלֹשַׁת נְשֵׁי־בָנָיו אִתָּם
אֶל־הַתֵּבָה:

¹⁴ הֵמָּה וְכָל־הַחַיָּה לְמִינָהּ וְכָל־הַבְּהֵמָה לְמִינָהּ וְכָל־הָרֶמֶשׂ עַל־הָאָרֶץ לְמִינָהּ
וְכָל־הָעוֹף לְמִינָהּ כֹּל צֶפֶר כָּל־כָּנָף:

¹⁵ וַיָּבֹאוּ אֵלֶינָה אֶל־הַתֵּבָה שְׁנַיִם שָׁנִים מִכָּל־הַבֶּשֶׂר אֲשֶׁר־בּו רֹחַ חַיִּים:

¹⁶ וְהַבָּאִים זָכָר וּנְקֵבָה מִכָּל־בֶּשֶׂר בָּאוּ כְּאֲשֶׁר צִוָּה אֱלֹהִים וַיִּסְגֹּר יְהוָה בַּעֲדָיו:

^{7:11} In the six hundredth year of Noah's life, in the second month, the seventeenth day of the month, on that same day were all the fountains of the great deep broken open, and the windows of heaven were opened.

^{7:12} And the rain was upon the earth forty days and forty nights.

^{7:13} In the selfsame day Noah, and Shem, and Ham, and Yefet, the sons of Noah, and Noah's wife, and the three wives of his sons with them, entered into the ark;

^{7:14} they, and every beast after its kind, and all the cattle after their kind, and every creeping thing that creeps on the earth after its kind, and every bird after its kind, every bird of every sort.

^{7:15} And they went in to Noah into the ark, two and two of all flesh in which is the breath of life.

^{7:16} And they that went in, went in male and female of all flesh, as God had commanded him: and the Lord shut him in.



5

The Ark Floats

The Ark Floats

The water rose and rose and lifted the ark right off the ground. The ark floated on the face of the waters, higher than the tallest mountains. Inside it was warm and noisy — mooing and roaring and chirping. The sisters peeked out of the tzohar at the gray water everywhere. Aviya read that the waters swelled on the earth for one hundred and fifty days. "That's a long time to be on a boat," said Tzofia.

Look closely: How long did the waters swell on the earth?

One hundred and fifty days (7:24).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 7:17-24

וַיְהִי הַמַּבּוּל אַרְבָּעִים יוֹם עַל־הָאָרֶץ וַיִּרְבוּ הַמַּיִם וַיִּשְׂאוּ אֶת־הַתֵּבָה וַתָּרָם מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ: ¹⁷

וַיִּגְבְּרוּ הַמַּיִם וַיִּרְבוּ מְאֹד עַל־הָאָרֶץ וַתֵּלֶךְ הַתֵּבָה עַל־פְּנֵי הַמַּיִם: ¹⁸

וְהַמַּיִם גָּבְרוּ מְאֹד מְאֹד עַל־הָאָרֶץ וַיִּכְסּוּ כָּל־הַהָרִים הַגְּבוּהִים אֲשֶׁר־תַּחַת כָּל־הַשָּׁמַיִם: ¹⁹

חֲמֵשׁ עָשָׂרָה אַמָּה מִלְּמַעְלָה גָּבְרוּ הַמַּיִם וַיִּכְסּוּ הַהָרִים: ²⁰

וַיָּנוּעַ כָּל־בֶּשֶׂר הַרְמֵשׁ עַל־הָאָרֶץ בְּעוֹף וּבַבְּהֵמָה וּבַחַיָּה וּבְכָל־הַשָּׁרֹץ הַשֹּׁרֵץ עַל־הָאָרֶץ וְכָל־הָאָדָם: ²¹

כָּל אֲשֶׁר נִשְׁמַת־רוּחַ חַיִּים בְּאַפִּיו מִכָּל אֲשֶׁר בָּחַרְבָה מִתּוֹ: ²²

וַיַּחַם אֶת־כָּל־הַיְּקוּם אֲשֶׁר עַל־פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה מֵאָדָם עַד־בְּהֵמָה עַד־רֶמֶשׂ וְעַד־עוֹף הַשָּׁמַיִם וַיָּמָחוּ מִן־הָאָרֶץ וַיִּשְׂאָר אֲדֹנָיִךְ וְאֲשֶׁר אִתּוֹ בַּתֵּבָה: ²³

וַיִּגְבְּרוּ הַמַּיִם עַל־הָאָרֶץ חֲמֵשִׁים וּמָאתַיִם יוֹם: ²⁴

^{7:17} And the flood was forty days upon the earth; and the waters increased, and bore up the ark, and it was raised above the earth.

^{7:18} And the waters prevailed, and were increased greatly upon the earth; and the ark went upon the face of the waters.

^{7:19} And the waters prevailed exceedingly upon the earth; and all the high mountains, that were under the whole heaven, were covered.

^{7:20} Fifteen cubits upward did the waters prevail; and the mountains were covered.

^{7:21} And all flesh perished that moved upon the earth, both of birds, and of cattle, and of beasts, and of every creeping thing that creeps upon the earth, and all mankind:

^{7:22} all in whose nostrils was the breath of life, of all that was on the dry land, died.

^{7:23} And He destroyed every living substance which was upon the face of the ground, both man, and cattle, and creeping things, and the birds of the heaven; they were destroyed from the earth: and Noah only remained alive, and they that were with him in the ark.

^{7:24} And the waters prevailed upon the earth a hundred and fifty days.



6

God Remembered Noah

God Remembered Noah

Then God remembered Noah and all the animals in the ark. He sent a wind over the earth, and the waters began to go down. The fountains of the deep closed, and the rain stopped. Bump! The ark stopped moving. Aviya read: in the seventh month, on the seventeenth day, the ark came to rest on the mountains of Ararat. Lielle clapped. Tzofia shouted, "We landed!"

Look closely: Where did the ark come to rest?

On the mountains of Ararat (8:4).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 8:1-4

¹ וַיִּזְכֹּר אֱלֹהִים אֶת־נֹחַ וְאֶת כָּל־הַחַיָּה וְאֶת־כָּל־הַבְּהֵמָה אֲשֶׁר אִתּוֹ בַּתֵּבָה
וַיַּעֲבֵר אֱלֹהִים רוּחַ עַל־הָאָרֶץ וַיִּשְׁכּוּ הַמַּיִם:

² וַיִּסְכְּרוּ מַעְיֵנֹת תְּהוֹם וְאַרְבַּת הַשָּׁמַיִם וַיִּכְלֹא הַגֶּשֶׁם מִן־הַשָּׁמַיִם:

³ וַיִּשְׁבוּ הַמַּיִם מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ הַלֹּדֶז וְשׁוּב וַיִּחְסְרוּ הַמַּיִם מִקְצֵה חֲמִשִּׁים וּמֵאָת יוֹם:

⁴ וַתָּנַח הַתֵּבָה בַּחֹדֶשׁ הַשְּׁבִיעִי בִּשְׁבַע־עָשָׂר יוֹם לַחֹדֶשׁ עַל הָרֵי אָרָרָט:

^{8:1} And God remembered Noah, and every living thing, and all the cattle that were with him in the ark: and God made a wind to pass over the earth, and the waters were assuaged;

^{8:2} the fountains also of the deep and the windows of heaven were stopped,

^{8:3} and the rain from heaven was restrained; and the waters receded from the earth continually: and after the end of a hundred and fifty days the waters were abated.

^{8:4} And the ark rested in the seventh month, on the seventeenth day of the month, upon the mountains of Ararat.



7

The Raven and the Dove

The Raven and the Dove

After forty days, Noah opened the window of the ark and sent out a raven. It flew back and forth, back and forth, until the water dried up. Then he sent out a dove. But the dove found no place to rest her foot, because water still covered the earth. So she came back. Tzofia held her breath as Noah reached out his hand and brought the dove back in. "She's safe," whispered Aviya.

Look closely: Why did the dove come back the first time?

She found no resting place for her foot, because water was still on the face of the earth (8:9).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 8:6-9

6 וַיְהִי מִקֵּץ אַרְבָּעִים יוֹם וַיִּפְתַּח נֹחַ אֶת־חֲלוֹן הַתֵּבָה אֲשֶׁר עָשָׂה:

7 וַיִּשְׁלַח אֶת־הָעֹרֵב וַיֵּצֵא וַיָּצוּא וְשׁוֹב עַד־יִבְשֹׁת הַמַּיִם מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ:

8 וַיִּשְׁלַח אֶת־הַיּוֹנָה מֵאֵתוֹ לִרְאוֹת הַקָּלוּ הַמַּיִם מֵעַל פְּנֵי הָאֲדָמָה:

9 וְלֹא־מָצְאָה הַיּוֹנָה מְנוּחַ לְכַף־רַגְלָהּ וַתָּשֶׁב אֵלָיו אֶל־הַתֵּבָה כִּי־מַיִם עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ וַיִּשְׁלַח יָדוֹ וַיִּקְחָהּ וַיָּבֵא אֹתָהּ אֵלָיו אֶל־הַתֵּבָה:

8:6 And it came to pass at the end of forty days, that Noah opened the window of the ark which he had made:

8:7 and he sent forth the raven, which went forth to and fro, until the waters were dried up from off the earth.

8:8 Also he sent forth the dove from him, to see if the waters were abated from the face of the ground;

8:9 but the dove found no rest for the sole of her foot, and she returned to him into the ark, for the waters were on the face of the whole earth: then he put out his hand, and took her, and pulled her in to him into the ark.



An Olive Leaf!

Noach waited seven more days and sent the dove out again. In the evening, the dove came back — and in her mouth was a freshly plucked olive leaf! "Something is growing again!" shouted Tzofia. Lielle reached for the leaf. Noach waited another seven days and sent the dove out once more. This time she did not come back at all. "She found a home," said Aviya.

Look closely: What was in the dove's mouth?

A freshly plucked olive leaf (8:11).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 8:10-12

10 וַיַּחַל עוֹד שְׁבַעַת יָמִים אַחֲרָיִם וַיִּסֹּף שְׁלַח אֶת־הַיּוֹנָה מִן־הַתֵּבָה:

11 וַתָּבֹא אֵלָיו הַיּוֹנָה לָעֵת עֶרֶב וְהָיָה עָלֶיהָ־זֵית טֶרֶף בִּפְיָהּ וַיֵּדַע נֹחַ כִּי־קָלָו הַמַּיִם מֵעַל הָאָרֶץ:

12 וַיַּחַל עוֹד שְׁבַעַת יָמִים אַחֲרָיִם וַיִּשְׁלַח אֶת־הַיּוֹנָה וְלֹא־יָסָפָה שׁוּב־אֵלָיו עוֹד:

8:10 And he waited yet another seven days; and again he sent forth the dove out of the ark;

8:11 and the dove came in to him in the evening; and, lo, in her mouth was an olive leaf plucked off: so Noah knew that the waters were abated from off the earth.

8:12 And he waited yet another seven days; and sent forth the dove; which returned not again to him any more.



Out of the Ark

God said to Noah: "Go out of the ark — you, your wife, your sons and your sons' wives — and bring out every living thing with you." The big door opened. The animals poured out onto the dry, fresh land — running, hopping, flying. Tzofia ran too. Then Noah built an altar to Hashem and brought offerings. The sisters stood quietly and watched the smoke rise.

Look closely: What was the first thing Noah built after leaving the ark?

An altar to Hashem (8:20).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 8:15-20

15 וַיְדַבֵּר אֱלֹהִים אֶל־נֹחַ לֵאמֹר:

16 צֵא מִן־הַתֵּבָה אַתָּה וְאִשְׁתְּךָ וּבְנֶיךָ וּנְשֵׁי־בְנֶיךָ אִתְּךָ:

17 כָּל־הַחַיָּה אֲשֶׁר־אִתְּךָ מִכָּל־בֶּשֶׂר בְּעוֹף וּבַבְּהֵמָה וּבְכָל־הָרֶמֶשׂ עַל־הָאָרֶץ הוֹצֵא [הִיצֵא] אִתְּךָ וְשָׂרְצוּ בָאָרֶץ וּפְרוּ וּרְבוּ עַל־הָאָרֶץ:

18 וַיֵּצֵא־נֹחַ וּבְנָיו וְאִשְׁתּוֹ וּנְשֵׁי־בְנָיו אִתּוֹ:

19 כָּל־הַחַיָּה כָּל־הָרֶמֶשׂ וְכָל־הָעוֹף כֹּל רוֹמֵשׂ עַל־הָאָרֶץ לְמִשְׁפְּחֹתֵיהֶם יֵצְאוּ מִן־הַתֵּבָה:

20 וַיְבֵן נֹחַ מִזְבֵּחַ לַיהוָה וַיִּקַּח מִכָּל הַבְּהֵמָה הַטְּהוֹרָה וּמִכָּל הָעוֹף הַטְּהוֹר וַיַּעַל עֹלֹת בַּמִּזְבֵּחַ:

8:15 And God spoke to Noah, saying,

8:16 Go out of the ark, thou, and thy wife, and thy sons, and thy sons' wives with thee.

8:17 Bring out with thee every living thing that is with thee, of all flesh, both of birds, and of cattle, and of every creeping thing that creeps on the earth; that they may breed abundantly on the earth, and be fruitful, and multiply upon the earth.

8:18 And Noah went out, and his sons, and his wife, and his sons' wives with him:

8:19 every beast, every creeping thing, and every bird, and whatever creeps on the earth, after their kinds, went out of the ark.

8:20 And Noah built an altar to the Lord; and took of every clean beast, and of every clean bird, and offered burnt offerings on the altar.



The Rainbow

Then God made a promise — a brit — with Noah and every living creature: never again would the waters become a flood to destroy all life. And He gave a sign: "My bow I have set in the cloud." A rainbow stretched across the whole sky. Tzofia named every color. Lielle reached up to grab it. "Every time we see one," said Aviya, "it's the sign of the promise."

Look closely: What is the rainbow a sign of?

God's covenant that the waters will never again become a flood to destroy all flesh (9:15).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 9:12-16

¹² וַיֹּאמֶר אֱלֹהִים זֹאת אוֹת־הַבְּרִית אֲשֶׁר־אֲנִי נֹתֵן בֵּינִי וּבֵינֵיכֶם וּבֵין כָּל־נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה אֲשֶׁר אִתְּכֶם לְדֹרֹת עוֹלָם:

¹³ אֶת־קִשְׁתִּי נִתְּתִי בָעָנָן וְהָיְתָה לְאוֹת בְּרִית בֵּינִי וּבֵין הָאָרֶץ:

¹⁴ וְהָיָה בָעָנָנִי עָנָן עַל־הָאָרֶץ וְנִרְאָתָה הַקֶּשֶׁת בָּעָנָן:

¹⁵ וְזָכַרְתִּי אֶת־בְּרִיתִי אֲשֶׁר בֵּינִי וּבֵינֵיכֶם וּבֵין כָּל־נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה בְּכָל־בֶּשֶׂר וְלֹא־יְהִיָּה עוֹד הַמַּיִם לַמַּבּוּל לְשַׁחַת כָּל־בֶּשֶׂר:

¹⁶ וְהָיְתָה הַקֶּשֶׁת בָּעָנָן וְרָאִיתִיהָ לְזִכֹּר בְּרִית עוֹלָם בֵּין אֱלֹהִים וּבֵין כָּל־נֶפֶשׁ חַיָּה בְּכָל־בֶּשֶׂר אֲשֶׁר עַל־הָאָרֶץ:

^{9:12} And God said, This is the token of the covenant which I make between Me and you and every living creature that is with you, for perpetual generations:

^{9:13} I have set My bow in the cloud, and it shall be for a token of a covenant between Me and the earth.

^{9:14} And it shall come to pass, when I bring a cloud over the earth, that the bow shall be seen in the cloud:

^{9:15} and I will remember My covenant, which is between Me and you and every living creature of all flesh; and the waters shall no more become a flood to destroy all flesh.

^{9:16} And the bow shall be in the cloud; and I will look upon it, that I may remember the everlasting covenant between God and every living creature of all flesh that is upon the earth.



A Tower to the Sky

Years later, the whole earth had one language and the same words. People settled in a valley in Shinar and baked bricks. "Let's build a city," they said, "and a tower with its top in the sky, and make a name for ourselves, so we won't be scattered." Hashem came down to see the city and the tower. He mixed up their language so they couldn't understand each other. "Brick!" said one. "Huh?" said another. And Hashem scattered them over the whole earth.

Look closely: Why was the city called Babel?

Because there Hashem mixed up (balal) the language of all the earth (11:9).

¹ וַיְהִי כָל־הָאָרֶץ שָׁפָה אֶחָת וּדְבָרִים אֶחָדִים:

² וַיְהִי בְּנִסְעָם מִקֵּדָם וַיִּמְצְאוּ בְּקֵעָה בְּאֶרֶץ שִׁנְאָר וַיֵּשְׁבוּ שָׁם:

³ וַיֹּאמְרוּ אִישׁ אֶל־רֵעֵהוּ הֵבָה נִלְבְּנָה לְבָנִים וְנִשְׂרָפָה לְשִׂרְפָּה וְתָהִי לָהֶם הַלְבְּנָה לְאַבֵּן וְהַחֹמֶר הִיָּה לָהֶם לַחֹמֶר:

⁴ וַיֹּאמְרוּ הֵבָה נִבְנֶה־לָנוּ עִיר וּמִגְדָּל וְרֹאשׁוֹ בַשָּׁמַיִם וְנַעֲשֶׂה־לָנוּ שֵׁם פֶּן־נִפּוּץ עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ:

⁵ וַיֵּרֶד יְהוָה לִרְאוֹת אֶת־הָעִיר וְאֶת־הַמִּגְדָּל אֲשֶׁר בָּנוּ בְנֵי הָאָדָם:

⁶ וַיֹּאמֶר יְהוָה הֵן עַם אֶחָד וּשְׁפָה אֶחָת לְכָל־ם וְזֶה הַחֲלֹם לַעֲשׂוֹת וְעַתָּה לֹא־יִבָּצֵר מֵהֶם כָּל אֲשֶׁר יִזְמוּ לַעֲשׂוֹת:

⁷ הֵבָה נֵרְדָּה וְנַבְלָה שָׁם שְׂפָתָם אֲשֶׁר לֹא יִשְׁמְעוּ אִישׁ שְׂפַת רֵעֵהוּ:

⁸ וַיִּפֶץ יְהוָה אֹתָם מִשָּׁם עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ וַיַּחְדְּלוּ לִבְנֹת הָעִיר:

⁹ עַל־כֵּן קָרָא שְׁמָהּ בָּבֶל כִּי־שָׁם בָּלַל יְהוָה שְׂפַת כָּל־הָאָרֶץ וּמִשָּׁם הִפְיִצָם יְהוָה עַל־פְּנֵי כָל־הָאָרֶץ:

^{11:1} And the whole earth was of one language, and of one speech.

^{11:2} And it came to pass, as they journeyed from the east, that they found a plain in the land of Shin'ar; and they dwelt there.

^{11:3} And they said to one another, Come, let us make bricks, and burn them thoroughly. And they had brick for stone, and slime had they for mortar.

^{11:4} And they said, Come, let us build us a city and a tower, whose top may reach to heaven; and let us make us a name, lest we be scattered abroad upon the face of the whole earth.

^{11:5} And the Lord came down to see the city and the tower, which the children of men were building.

^{11:6} And the Lord said, Behold, the people is one, and they have all one language; and this they begin to do: and now nothing will be withheld from them, which they have schemed to do.

^{11:7} Come, let us go down, and there confound their language, that they may not understand one another's speech.

^{11:8} So the Lord scattered them abroad from there upon the face of all the earth: and they ceased to build the city.

^{11:9} Therefore is the name of it called Babel; because the Lord did there confound the language of all the earth: and from thence did the Lord scatter them abroad upon the face of all the earth.



Someone New

Many generations later, the Chumash told of a family: Terach, and his sons Avram, Nachor and Haran. Avram married Sarai. Terach took Avram, Sarai and his grandson Lot and left Ur Kasdim to go to the land of Canaan — and they came as far as Charan, and settled there. The page began to glow. Aviya smiled and closed the Chumash. "Next week," she said, "Hashem is going to tell Avram to go."

Look closely: Where was Terach's family heading when they left Ur Kasdim?

To the land of Canaan — they came as far as Charan and settled there (11:31).

FROM THE TORAH · BERESHIT 11:26-32

26 וַיְחִי־תֵרַח שִׁבְעִים שָׁנָה וַיֻּלְּדֵ אֶת־אַבְרָם אֶת־נָחֹר וְאֶת־הָרָן:

27 וְאֵלֶּה תּוֹלְדֹת תֵּרַח תֵּרַח הֵולִיד אֶת־אַבְרָם אֶת־נָחֹר וְאֶת־הָרָן וְהָרָן הֵולִיד אֶת־לוֹט:

28 וַיָּמָת הָרָן עַל־פְּנֵי תֵרַח אָבִיו בְּאֶרֶץ מוֹלְדֹתוֹ בְּאוּר כַּשְׁדִּים:

29 וַיִּקַּח אַבְרָם וְנָחֹר לָהֶם נָשִׁים שָׁם אֵשֶׁת־אַבְרָם שָׂרִי וְשָׁם אֵשֶׁת־נָחֹר מִלְכָּה בַת־הָרָן אֲבִי־מִלְכָּה וְאֲבִי יִשְׂכָּה:

30 וַתְּהִי שָׂרִי עֲקָרָה אֵין לָהּ יֶלֶד:

31 וַיִּקַּח תֵּרַח אֶת־אַבְרָם בְּנוֹ וְאֶת־לוֹט בֶּן־הָרָן בְּרֵבְנוֹ וְאֵת שָׂרִי כֶלְתּוֹ אֵשֶׁת אַבְרָם בְּנוֹ וַיֵּצְאוּ אֹתָם מֵאוּר כַּשְׁדִּים לָלֶכֶת אֶרֶץ חַרָּן וַיָּבֹאוּ עַד־חָרָן וַיֵּשְׁבוּ שָׁם:

32 וַיְהִיו יְמֵי־תֵרַח חֲמֵשׁ שָׁנִים וּמֵאתַיִם שָׁנָה וַיָּמָת תֵּרַח בְּחָרָן:

11:26 And Terah lived seventy years, and begot Avram, Nahor, and Haran.

11:27 Now these are the generations of Terah: Terah begot Avram, Nahor, and Haran; and Haran begot Lot.

11:28 And Haran died before his father Terah in the land of his nativity, in Ur-kasdim.

11:29 And Avram and Nahor took wives for themselves; the name of Avram's wife was Saray; and the name of Nahor's wife, Milka, the daughter of Haran, the father of Milka, and the father of Yiska.

11:30 But Saray was barren; she had no child.

11:31 And Terah took Avram his son, and Lot the son of Haran his son's son, and Saray his daughter in law, his son Avram's wife; and they went out with them from Ur-kasdim, to go into the land of Kena'an; and they came to Haran, and dwelt there.

11:32 And the days of Terah were two hundred and five years: and Terah died in Haran.

The End

Three sisters climb aboard the ark and ride out the flood. Read it again this Shabbat — and see how much more you can find in the pesukim.

Pesukim from Sefaria (Tanach with Nikkud · The Koren Jerusalem Bible). Illustrations made with FLUX.2 [klein]. Peshat fidelity checked with Jev.